Argument Against Measure U Infrastructure Bond

Measure U borrows $300 million with no comprehensive capital plan, no binding commitment to specific projects, and no budget for maintaining new facilities. Higher interest rates make the total costs $550-600 million. High inflation and competing spending priorities, with no blueprint for success, risks taking on enormous debt without addressing Berkeley's most pressing infrastructure needs.

Borrowing makes sense when it finances high-priority capital projects that serve residents for decades. Council identified 35 **potential** projects to fund with bond revenues, but did not prioritize or legally commit to any of them.

This list could change any time and all 35 projects are unlikely to be funded – it's a $300 million blank check. Berkeley's procurement guidelines have allowed projects to double in cost. Bond Measure T1 (2016) projects cost about 15% more than originally budgeted.

Bonds should finance long-lived capital assets. This measure mixes in operating costs and routine maintenance that should be funded through special or General Fund recurring revenue. Examples include:

- $14 million for sidewalk repairs, even though voters approved Measure FF in 2024 to fix Berkeley's sidewalk and pathway backlog.
- $6.7 million for seismic improvements to the Old City Hall, despite needing more than $100 million in repairs.
- $25 million for King Pool, despite longstanding concerns about the unequal distribution of recreational facilities between North and South Berkeley.

Berkeley residents devoted countless volunteer hours through 2025 to develop Vision 2050, a thoughtful comprehensive long-term strategy for the City's capital needs. Yet its recommendations have not been implemented or meaningfully incorporated into Measure U.

Before asking taxpayers to commit up to $550-600 million, the City should establish clear priorities, make binding commitments to bonafide capital projects, and present a credible plan for maintaining new facilities.

Berkeley can do better. Vote NO on Measure U.

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CITY OF BERKELEY
CITY CLERK DEPARTMENT

s/ Isabelle Gaston
Assistant Treasurer, Affordable Berkeley

s/ Donna DiDiemar
Neighborhood Activist

s/ Michael Katz
Writer and Cyclist

s/ Joshua Glatt
Software Engineer and Composer

s/ Stephen Tracy
Retired Public School Teacher

Submitted on behalf of: Affordable Berkeley. Isabelle Gaston, Assistant Treasurer

Isabelle Gaston